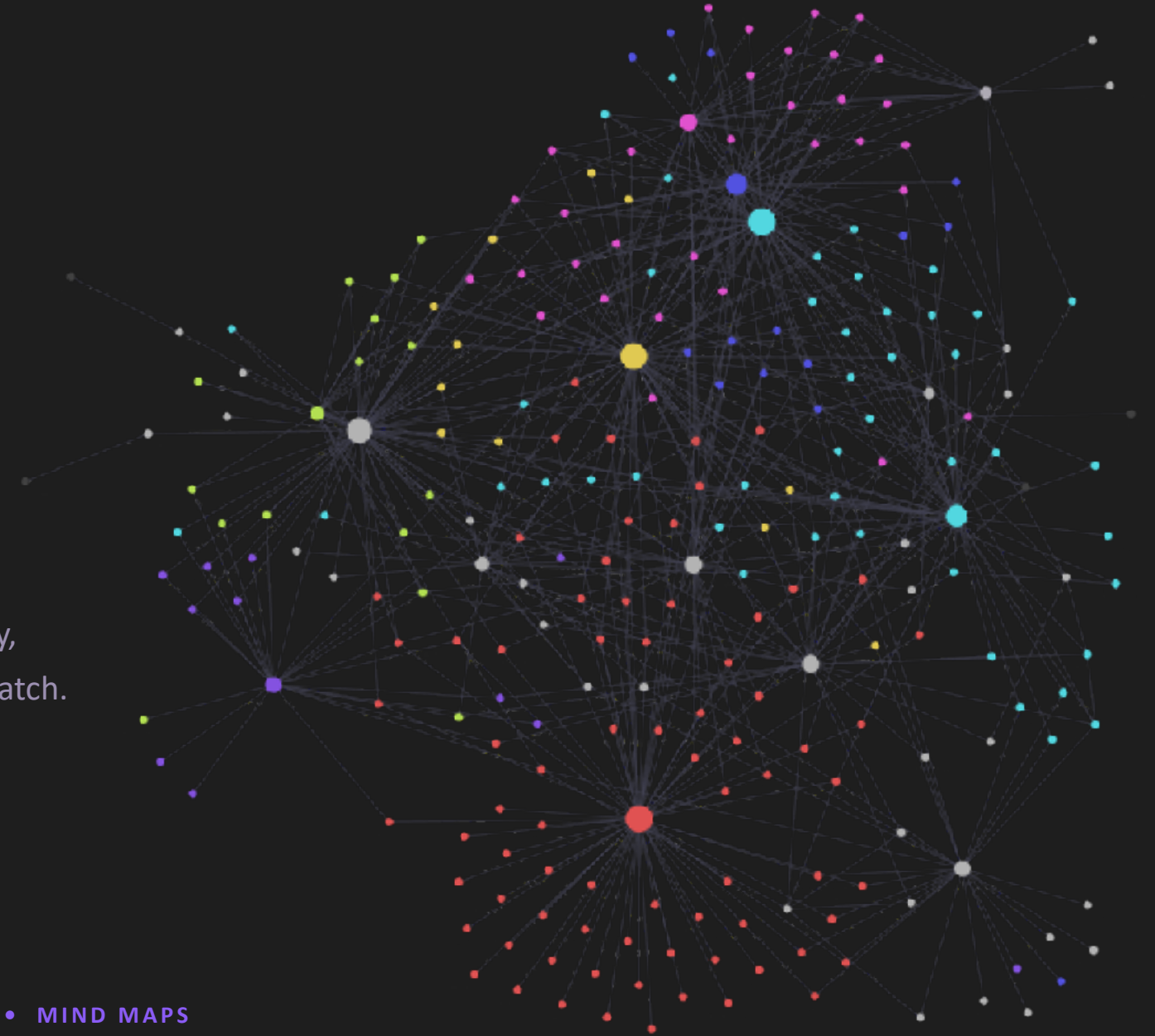


A BEGINNER'S GUIDE

Obsidian

A note-taking tool for research, science, bibliography,
and project & task management, explained from scratch.



PLAIN-TEXT NOTES • LOCAL FILES • LINKED THINKING • MIND MAPS

What is Obsidian ?

Obsidian is a free app for taking notes as plain-text Markdown files, stored locally on your computer. Instead of folders alone, you connect notes to each other with links - turning your notes into a personal, explorable web of ideas.



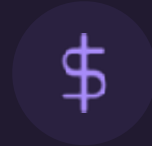
Markdown files

Notes are plain .md text files you fully own



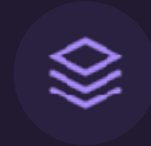
Your computer

Stored locally in a folder called a "vault"



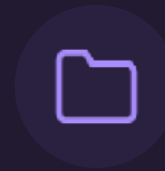
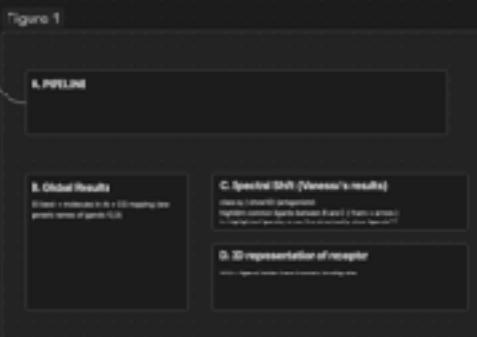
Free to use

Core app is free; optional paid sync/publish

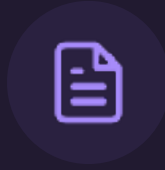


1000+ plugins

Extend it for almost any workflow

[illegible]

 Vault A folder on your computer holding all your notes. You can have several vaults for different areas of life.



 Notes Each note is a simple Markdown text file : readable in any text editor, forever, even without Obsidian.



 Graph view A visual map of every note and link - patterns and connections you didn't know were there become visible.



 Links `[[ ]]` Type `[[note name]]` to connect two notes. Links can be created before the target note even exists.

Each note is a simple Markdown text file :
readable in any text editor, forever, even without
Obsidian.

A visual map of every note and link -
patterns and connections you didn't know
were there become visible.

Type `[[note name]]` to connect two notes.
Links can be created before the target note
even exists.

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



See backlinks automatically



Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly

The screenshot displays the Obsidian application interface. On the left, a sidebar shows a file explorer with a 'Bibliography' folder containing various subfolders like 'ADA', 'All Atom MD', 'Molecular Dynamics', etc. The main area shows a note titled 'Gutierrez-2019'. The note content includes properties (Title, Year, Link, Journal), authors (M. Gertrude Gutierrez, Jacob Derrell, Ketz L. White, Lucie C. Dalle Ore, Vedim Chernozov, Raymond O. Stevens and Noah Melamed), categories (GPCRs, Protein-Lipid Interaction, Drug Research), and an abstract. The abstract text is: 'Giant unilamellar protein vesicles (GUPs) were formed with the adenosine A_{2A} receptor (A $_{2A}$ R) incorporated in the lipid bilayer and protein partitioning into the liquid ordered and liquid disordered phases was observed. When no ligand is bound, A $_{2A}$ R partitions preferentially into the liquid disordered phase of GUPs, while ligand-bound A $_{2A}$ R partitions into the liquid ordered phase of GUPs. 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC), 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC) and cholesterol (chol) using a detergent-assisted method'.

Below the note, a preview of the article is shown. The article is titled 'The lipid phase preference of the adenosine A_{2A} receptor depends on its ligand binding state' and is published in ChemComm. The authors listed are M. Gertrude Gutierrez, Jacob Derrell, Ketz L. White, Lucie C. Dalle Ore, Vedim Chernozov, Raymond O. Stevens, and Noah Melamed. The abstract of the article is also visible, starting with 'Giant unilamellar protein vesicles (GUPs) were formed with the adenosine A_{2A} receptor (A $_{2A}$ R) incorporated in the lipid bilayer and protein partitioning into the liquid ordered and liquid disordered phases was observed. When no ligand is bound, A $_{2A}$ R partitions preferentially into the liquid disordered phase of GUPs, while ligand-bound A $_{2A}$ R partitions into the liquid ordered phase of GUPs. 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC), 1,3-bis(sn-3'-phosphatidyl-sn-glycerol-3-phosphocholine (DOPC) and cholesterol (chol) using a detergent-assisted method'.

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



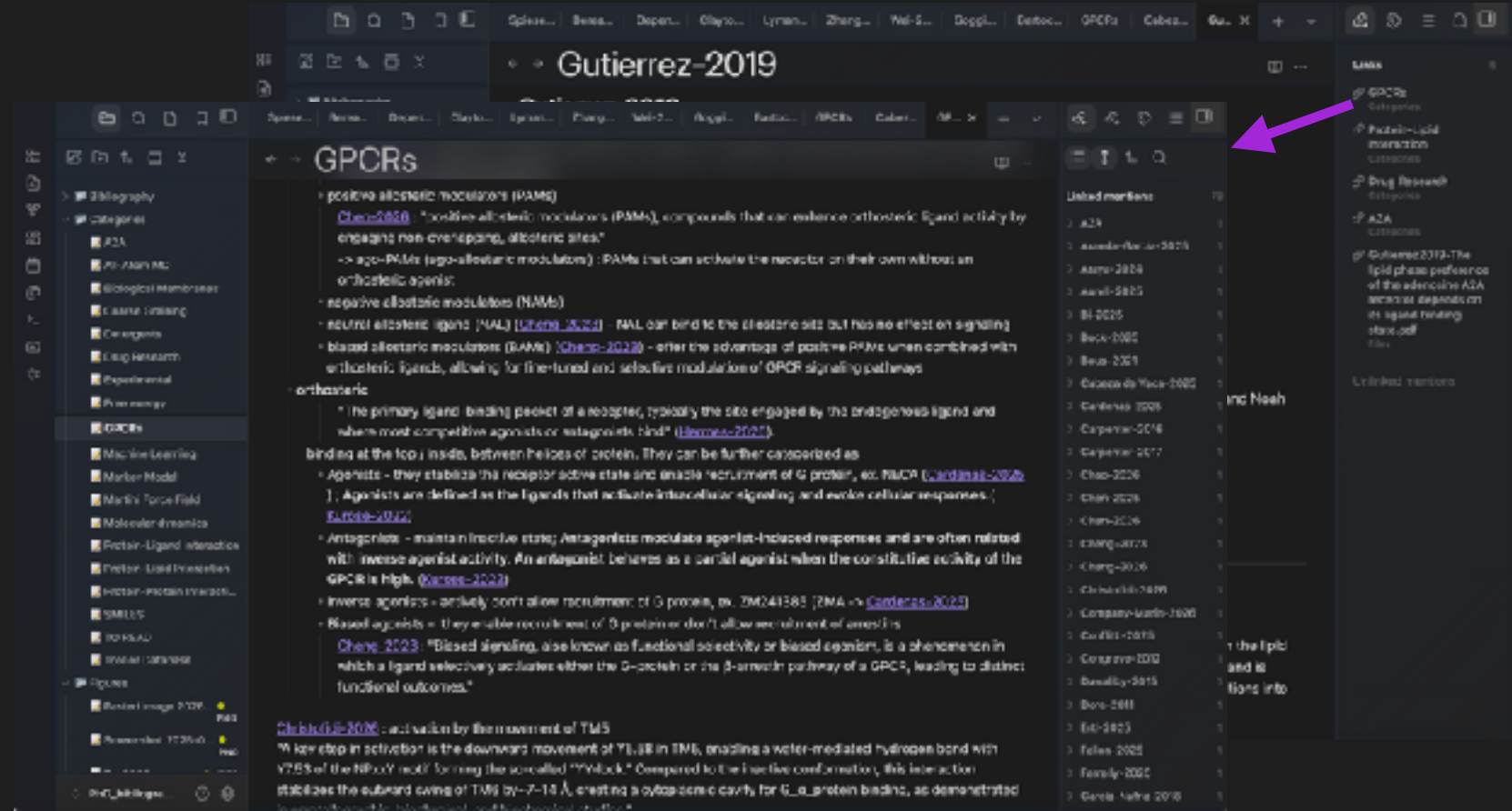
See backlinks automatically



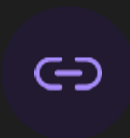
Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly



Bibliography with Obsidian



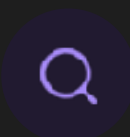
Connect ideas across papers



See backlink



Zoom out with network view



Full-text search

Bibliography with Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers



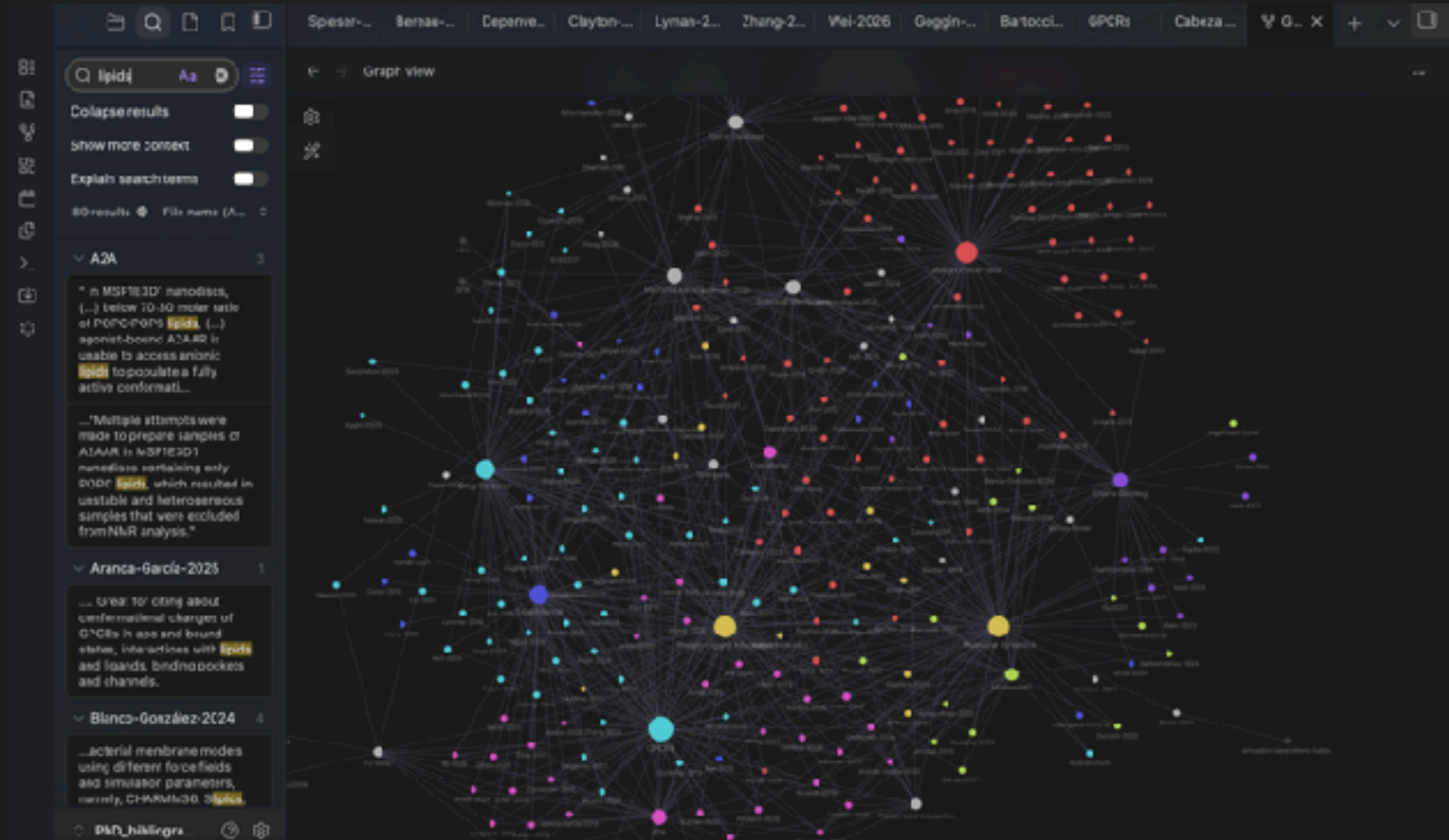
See backlinks automatically



Zoom out with the graph



Full-text search, instantly



Time management

Daily notes



One note per day, created automatically from a template : journal, log, or planner.

Calendar view



See a month at a glance and jump straight into any day's note.

Templates



Pre-fill each day with goals, a task list, planned experiments and meetings



← →

_Templates / Daily

▽ ⓘ ⋮

Daily

Links

• Meetings:

• Projects:

Todosy

Side notes

Results & figures

Sep 2026

< TODAY >

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
31	1	2	3	4	5	6
7	8	9	10	11	12	13
14	15	16	17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24	25	26	27
28	29	30	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

Time management

Daily notes

One note per day, created automatically from a template : journal, log, or planner.



Calendar view

See a month at a glance and jump straight into any day's note.



Templates

Pre-fill each day with goals, a task list, planned experiments and meetings



09-09-2026

Links

- Meetings: [09-09-2026 WedCal](#)
- Projects: [Calixar Ligand Screen](#)

Todosy [12/15]

Simulations [4/4]

Rerun:

- ☒ rerun replicate of APO-40µs system ☒ 2026-09-09
- ☒ duplicate HOLE-Co Martini 20µs ☒ 2026-09-09

Check:

- ☒ check system HOLE with removed ligand in VMD ☒ 2026-09-14
- ☒ check APO-40µs system in VMD ☒ 2026-09-14

Manuscript [4/5]

- ☒ work on figure 3 ☒ 2026-09-09 [3/3]
- ☒ 3A: allosteric regions (occupancy time, 3D-receptor+volume, mol-img) ☒ 2026-09-09
- ☒ 3B: five lig7 copies in allosteric regions (events snapshots above) ☒ 2026-09-09
- ☒ 3C: five lig309 copies in allosteric regions (events snapshots above) ☒ 2026-09-09

Sep
2026

< TODAY >

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
31	1	2	3	4	5	6
7	8	9	10	11	12	13
14	15	16	17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24	25	26	27
28	29	30	1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8	9	10	11

Tutorial on GitHub = your first vault

Table of contents

1. *What is Obsidian?*
2. *What is Markdown?*
3. *Installing Obsidian and opening this vault*
4. *The vault structure — what goes where*
5. *Templates — what they are and how to use them*
6. *How to create a note step by step*
7. *How linking works — with a real example*
8. *How to embed images and figures*
9. *Recommended plugins and how to install them*
10. *Daily workflow suggestion*
11. *Bibliography management — importing from Zotero*

Tutorial on GitHub = your first vault

vault/	
└ Meetings/	one note per meeting
└ Daily/	one note per working day
└ Projects/	one note per research project
└ Protocols/	your experimental protocols
└ Experiments/	one note per experiment run
└ Results/	figures and graphical results
└ _Attachments/	images and files embedded in notes
└ _Templates/	templates (do not edit these)
└ README.md	quick reference guide

Meeting

Properties

📅 date

👤 people

📁 project

➕ Add property

dd/mm/yyyy

Empty

Empty

Meeting —

Date:

People:

Project: Projects/

Main topics

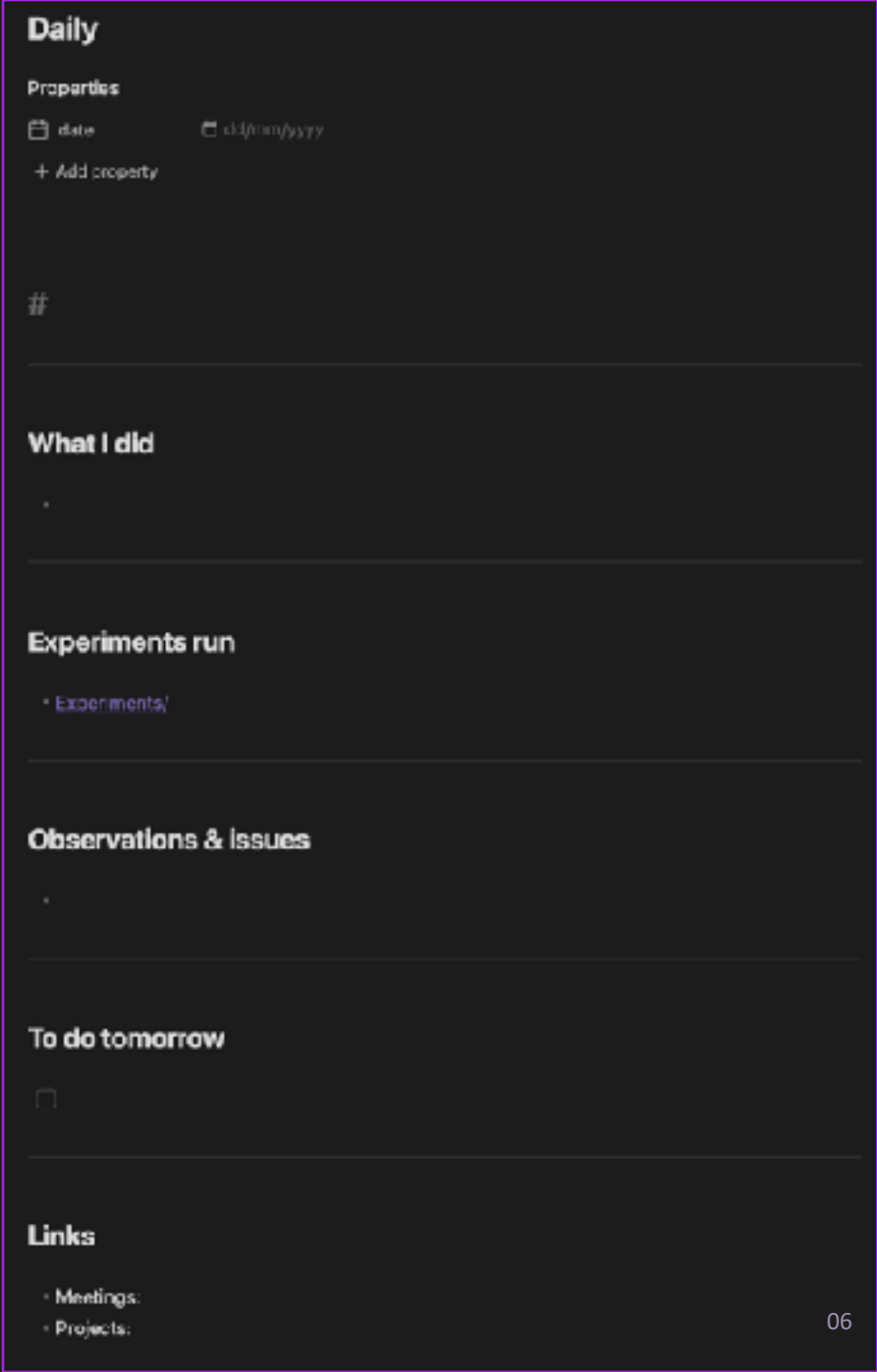
Notes

To do

Ideas

Tutorial on GitHub = your first vault

vault/	
└ Meetings/	one note per meeting
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└ Projects/	one note per research project
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└ README.md	quick reference guide



Tutorial on GitHub = your first vault

vault/	
└ Meetings/	one note per meeting
└ Daily/	one note per working day
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└ Experiments/	one note per experiment run
└ Results/	figures and graphical results
└ _Attachments/	images and files embedded in notes
└ _Templates/	templates (do not edit these)
└ README.md	quick reference guide

Protocol

Properties

date

do/ma/yyyy

version

v1

project

Empty

validated

yes / no

+ Add property

Protocol —

Project: [Projects/](#)

Version: v1

Validated:

Last updated:

Purpose

What is this protocol for?

Materials & reagents

Item	Quantity	Supplier / Reference

Steps

1.

2.

3.

Critical steps & warnings

06

0 backlinks 4 properties 70 words

Getting started, step by step

1

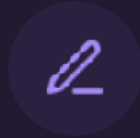


Install & open

Download Obsidian (free) for your computer and open vault from folder (GitHub tutorial) or create new vault from scratch.



2

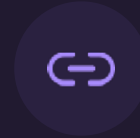


Write your first notes

Start plainly: one note per topic, paper, or day.



3



Start linking

As ideas repeat, connect them with `[[links]]` - your own tags, keywords, ideas. Structure emerges from your notes.



4



Use plugins

It's not necessary but very useful - start with Tasks, Calendar or Citations.

Getting started, step by step

The screenshot displays the 'PhDying Time of my Life' workspace in a Kanban view. The interface is divided into a left sidebar, a top header, and a main task board.

- Left Sidebar:** Contains navigation links for 'Today', 'Inbox', 'Upcoming', 'Forecast', 'Projects', 'Working On', 'Tags', 'Flagged', 'Table', 'Review', and 'Matrix' (which is currently selected). Below these are 'PROJECTS' with a list: '[[Caixar Ligand Screen]]' (17), '[[Protein LLLs interactions]]' (13), 'Administration' (5), and 'Bibliography' (7). At the bottom are 'OTHER VIEWS' including 'Events', 'Status', and 'Plan'.
- Top Header:** Shows '407 Tasks' and a 'Priority (High to Low)' filter.
- Main Task Board:** Organized into four columns based on priority and importance:
 - Urgent & important:** 20 tasks. Contains tasks like 'prepare and send a report on the progress of the project' and 'figure 2D : experimental results (MST) for lig210 and lig829 (KD)'.
 - Not Urgent & important:** 2 tasks. Contains a task about 'renn lipid binding analysis on smaller frame count cutoff'.
 - Urgent & Not important:** 0 tasks.
 - Not Urgent & Not important:** 365 tasks. Contains various tasks, including sending a report, a vacation report, and several citation links.

4



Use plugins

It's not necessary but very useful - start with Tasks, Calendar or Citations.

Pros



Free core app

Full note-taking features cost nothing; only sync/publish add-ons are paid.



You own your files

Plain Markdown files - no lock-in, no proprietary format, readable forever.



Works fully offline

No internet connection needed; everything lives on your device.



Deep customization

Community plugins and themes adapt it to almost any workflow.



Fast, local search

Instant full-text search across huge vaults, even with many PDFs attached.

Cons



Learning curve

Linking, plugins, and Markdown syntax take longer to learn than a simple notes app.



No built-in real-time collaboration

Not designed for co-editing a note live with others, unlike Notion or Google Docs.



Organization is on you

Few built-in rules - an unstructured vault can get messy without personal discipline.